

What else to watch: *A Trip to the Moon* (1902, pp.20–21) ■ *King Kong* (1933, p.49) ■ *Vasilissa the Beautiful* (1939) ■ *The Red Shoes* (1948, p.332) ■ *The Night of the Hunter* (1955, pp.118–21)

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The secret to it all is that Cocteau set out to make a movie that would stir adults; along the way he discovered the child's imagination, too.

David Thomson

Have You Seen...?, 2008

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The Beast's palace is more like a stage set than a fantasy world. The magic in the palace is surreal, rather than fantastic. Real hands and arms emerge from walls and tables to hold candles and pour drinks, and caryatids have real human faces that roll their eyes and blow smoke. It is reminiscent of the art of Salvador Dalí, rather than the fairy tales of the Brothers Grimm—unsettling, but also more



adult and more moving. With settings inspired by the engravings of Gustave Doré and paintings of Jan Vermeer, and exteriors shot at Château de la Roche Courbon and Raray in France, cinematographer Henri Alekan created a world of Gothic enchantment. Cocteau

Fainting at the sight of the Beast, Beauty is carried to her bed chamber. He tells her that he will ask her to marry him every day that they are together.

himself credited Alekan for achieving “a supernatural quality within the limits of realism.” ■



Jean Cocteau Director

Writer, artist, and director Jean Cocteau was born in 1889, near Paris. He published his first book of poetry when he was 19, which gave him an entrée to the literary and artistic avant-garde in Paris.

In 1917, Cocteau wrote *Parade*, the story for a ballet composed by Erik Satie for the Ballets Russes. His most famous novel was *Les Enfants Terribles* (1929). Cocteau directed his first short movie in 1930, about the mythical ancient Greek poet Orpheus, but it was

not until 1946, at the age of 57, that he made his first full-length movie, *La Belle et la Bête*. Four years later, he made a second movie about Orpheus, *Orphée*. He combined movies, poetry, and theater until his death, in 1963.

Key movies

1930 *The Blood of a Poet*

1946 *La Belle et la Bête*

1950 *Orphée*

1962 *The Testament of Orpheus*